

diff Cheat Sheet

Compare two text files line by line and read what changed.

Using it

```
diff old.txt new.txt
```

Option	What it does
-u	Unified format, the easiest to read (recommended)
-y	Shows the two files side by side
-q	Only says <i>whether</i> the files differ
-i	Ignores differences in upper/lower case
-w	Ignores all whitespace
-B	Ignores blank lines
-r	Compares two folders, including subfolders
-u old new > changes.diff	Saves the output to a file

Exit status: **0** means the files are the same, **1** means they differ, and **2** means there was an error.

Reading the default output

Each change starts with a command line in the form **old-lines letter new-lines**:

Letter	Meaning	Example
a	Add	5a6,7 : after old line 5, add new lines 6–7
d	Delete	3d2 : delete old line 3 (the files then line up at new line 2)
c	Change	8,9c8 : replace old lines 8–9 with new line 8

```
8,9c8
< old line eight  ← < = from the OLD file
< old line nine
---  ← separates old from new
> new line eight  ← > = from the NEW file
```

Reading unified output (-u)

```
--- old.txt      2026-10-01 09:00  ← --- = old file
+++ new.txt      2026-10-03 14:12  ← +++ = new file
@@ -10,4 +10,5 @@  ← old: starts at line 10, 4 lines · new: starts at line 10, 5 lines
  unchanged line  ← space = in both files
-removed line    ← - = only in old
+added line      ← + = only in new
+another added line
  unchanged line
```

- A changed line shows up as a **-** line followed by a **+** line.
- Each block starting with **@@** is one group of nearby changes. By default it includes 3 unchanged lines on each side for context.
- If a number in the **@@** header has no count, the count is 1. A count of **0** means that side is empty.
- **\ No newline at end of file** means the line above it has no line break at the end.

Quick memory aid: **< or - = old (left)** · **> or + = new (right)**